

Presentation Skills and Technical Communication

Getting a technical decision understood — and agreed — by people who will never read the code.

Seven chapters

- 01** Know the room
- 02** Structure the message
- 03** Make the technical land
- 04** Hold the room under pressure
- 05** Deliver it live and remote
- 06** Write it down: the decision memo
- 07** Rehearse and critique

01

Know the room

Who is deciding, what they fear, how much depth they want — and how to notice when you have lost them.

- 01** Know the room
- 02 Structure the message
- 03 Make the technical land
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- 05 Deliver it live and remote
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- 07 Rehearse and critique

Who is actually in the room?

THE GOAL

Before a single slide is written, know who decides, what they are afraid of, and how much they want to hear. The same recommendation is a different message in each room.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Classify an audience as executive, technical or mixed by what it decides, fears and wants first.
- Pick the opening line, depth and evidence for each audience type.
- Notice in real time that the room has stopped following, and choose one of three adjustments.

Power–Interest grid — who to map, and how much to tell them

Mendelow (1991). Standard stakeholder-mapping tool in strategy and project management; here it decides depth and evidence before you write a word.

1

High power, high interest

Manage closely. Your decider. Full Audience Card; the ask goes to them.

2

High power, low interest

Keep satisfied. One sentence in their language; do not make them work.

3

Low power, high interest

Keep informed. They read the appendix; give them the depth.

4

Low power, low interest

Monitor. A line in the memo distribution, nothing more.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

Executive audiences are usually high power / low interest — hence one page and the number. Technical audiences are often high interest — hence the depth. The mixed room has all four quadrants in it, which is why it needs layering.

The Audience Card (decides · fears · wants first · depth) is what you fill in for anyone in the top two quadrants.

THE RULE — Remember the name: Power–Interest grid.

Three audiences, three different questions in their heads

	Executive	Technical	Mixed
Who	CFO, business head, sponsor, steering committee	Architects, senior engineers, technology board, security	A steering meeting: sponsor + CTO + ops + compliance
Decides	Whether to spend, when, and who owns the risk	Whether the approach is sound and fits the standards	The whole group decides Whether to proceed — each member should be satisfied on their own criterion
Fears	Surprises, open-ended cost, being embarrassed later	Hidden complexity, non-standard choices, "it will not scale"	Being the one who did not ask the obvious question
Wants first	The decision, the number, the date, the confidence	The shape of the solution and the trade-offs you rejected	One sentence each can understand, then a way to go deeper
Depth	One page. Detail only on request.	As deep as you can defend.	Layered: headline → one level down → appendix

THE RULE — Write the audience card before the first slide: decides · fears · wants first · depth.

The same recommendation, opened for the CTO

BEFORE — what usually gets said

"So we started by looking at the current database. It is on version 11, which is end-of-life next year. We benchmarked three options over four weeks. The first one had licensing issues, the second one had a problem with the replication lag, which was about 4 seconds in our tests, and the third one, which is the managed service, came out best on most measures, so our recommendation is probably to go with that, although there are still some questions about cost."

AFTER — the same content, made to land

"Recommendation: move the orders database to the managed PostgreSQL service before the version-11 end-of-life in March.

Two alternatives were benchmarked and rejected: self-hosted upgrade (replication lag 4 s under load, fails our 1 s target) and the licensed option (cost 2.3× over three years).

What I need from this board: agreement that a managed service is acceptable under the platform standard. The open cost question is on page 3 and does not change the recommendation."

THE RULE — The technical room wants the shape of the answer and the trade-offs you rejected — not the diary of how you got there.

The same recommendation, opened for the CFO

BEFORE — the CTO version, reused

"Recommendation: move the orders database to the managed PostgreSQL service before the version-11 end-of-life in March. Two alternatives were benchmarked: self-hosted upgrade had replication lag of 4 seconds under load against our 1-second target, and the licensed option came out at 2.3× cost over three years because of per-core pricing on the standby nodes..."

AFTER — the same content, made to land

"We need to move the orders database before March or we lose vendor support. The option I recommend costs about \$310k over three years — the cheapest of the three that meets our reliability target — and needs no new headcount.

What I need from you today: approval of the \$310k and a named owner on the finance side for the contract.

The technical comparison is in the appendix if you want it; the two alternatives I rejected were either slower than we can accept or 2.3× the cost."

THE RULE — For the executive, translate every technical fact into money, date, risk or people — or leave it in the appendix.

The mixed room: one sentence each can understand, then layers

BEFORE — aimed at one person

Presenter picks one audience and ignores the rest:

"So the key thing here is the replication lag on the self-hosted option, which at 4 seconds under load breaks read-after-write consistency for the order-status endpoint..."

The CFO checks her phone. The compliance lead is waiting for the word "audit". The CTO is the only person still in the conversation — and he already agreed last week.

AFTER — layered, one line per stakeholder

"We need to move the orders database before March, when support ends. I recommend the managed service: \$310k over three years, no new headcount, and it keeps the audit trail we have today.

For the technology board: it is the standard platform, no exception needed.

For compliance: same encryption and retention as now — page 4 has the mapping.

For finance: the number is fixed-price for year one.

I need a decision to proceed today; the detail behind each line is in the pack."

THE RULE — In a mixed room, give each decider one sentence in their language, then stop and let them pull the depth.

Signals that the room has stopped following

What you see	What it usually means	Adjustment
The senior person checks the time or phone	You are past their depth; they are waiting for the ask	ZOOM OUT — "The short version is..." then the ask
An engineer interrupts with an implementation question	They are engaged but you are too shallow for them	ZOOM IN — answer it in one line, offer the detail after
Someone writes but does not look up	They are collecting evidence for an objection	STOP AND ASK — "Is there something I should address now?"
Two people start a side conversation	You lost the thread; they are solving it without you	STOP AND ASK — name it: "Should we take that now?"
Nods, then silence when you ask for the decision	Agreement was social, not real; someone has a doubt	STOP AND ASK — "What would need to be true for a yes?"
The decider repeats your point back, differently	They are translating; your framing did not fit theirs	ZOOM OUT — adopt their words from that moment on

THE RULE — Three moves only: zoom out, zoom in, stop and ask. Pick one within ten seconds of the signal.

Six rooms, ten seconds each

THE VIGNETTES - YOU ARE MID-PRESENTATION WHEN...

- 1 The CFO glances at her phone, then at the clock
- 2 A platform engineer cuts in: “Which eviction policy are you using?”
- 3 The security lead has written half a page and hasn’t looked up once
- 4 The two ops managers start whispering to each other mid-slide
- 5 You ask for approval; everyone nods; nobody speaks
- 6 The CTO repeats your point back: “So basically we rent capacity instead of buying it”

DO THIS, PER VIGNETTE (NOTEBOOK)

- **1 What is the signal telling you?**
- **2 Pick the move: zoom out · zoom in · stop and ask**
- **3 Write your exact first words**
- **Worked - #1: past their depth → ZOOM OUT: “The short version is... and the ask is...”**

Ten seconds per vignette - the table gave you the map. Answers on the next slide.

What each room was saying

#	Vignette	What it means	The move + first words
1	CFO checks phone, then clock	Past her depth; waiting for the ask	ZOOM OUT - “The short version is... and the ask is...”
2	Engineer asks eviction policy	Engaged, but you are too shallow for him	ZOOM IN - answer in one line, offer detail after
3	Security lead writes, never looks up	Collecting evidence for an objection	STOP AND ASK - “Is there something I should address now?”
4	Ops managers whisper	You lost the thread; they solve it without you	STOP AND ASK - “Should we take that now?”
5	Nods, then silence at the ask	Agreement was social, not real	STOP AND ASK - “What would need to be true for a yes?”
6	CTO rephrases your point	Translating; your framing did not fit	ZOOM OUT - adopt his words from that moment on

Three moves only - the skill is picking one within ten seconds of the signal.

Adjusting depth in real time — what it sounds like

BEFORE — noticing, then doing the wrong thing

The sponsor has looked at her watch twice. The presenter notices and... speeds up:

"...so-the-failover-test-showed-recovery-in-under-90-seconds-and-then-we-also-checked-the-backup-restore-path-which-was-fine-and-the-next-thing-we-looked-at-was..."

Faster is not shallower. She now has the same content, delivered worse.

AFTER — zoom out, then the ask

Same signal. The presenter zooms out:

"Let me give you the short version. The failover works, the backups work, and the cost is inside the number I gave you. The one thing I need from you is the go-ahead to sign the contract this week.

I will stop there — if anyone wants the test results, I have them."

The sponsor: "Sign it. Send me the test summary."

THE RULE — When you see the signal, change the depth — never the speed.

02

Structure the message

Situation, complication, resolution. The decision first. One page on top, the detail underneath.

- 01 Know the room
- 02 Structure the message**
- 03 Make the technical land
- 04 Hold the room under pressure
- 05 Deliver it live and remote
- 06 Write it down: the decision memo
- 07 Rehearse and critique

Say it in an order the listener can use

THE GOAL

Engineers tell stories in the order the work happened. Deciders need them in the order a decision is made: where we are, what changed, what to do — decision first.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Restructure a chronological technical account into Situation → Complication → Resolution.
- Open with the decision needed and keep the analysis in reserve.
- Produce a one-page summary with a layered appendix that survives a two-minute or a twenty-minute meeting.

Pyramid Principle (SCQA) and BLUF — answer first

Barbara Minto, McKinsey, "The Pyramid Principle" (1987) — SCQA; BLUF (Bottom Line Up Front) from military staff writing. Both say the same thing: the conclusion goes first.

1

Situation

What is true and agreed. The reader nods.

2

Complication

What changed. The reason we are talking.

3

Question

The question that raises in the reader's mind — "so what do we do?"

4

Answer

Your recommendation — and in BLUF, this line moves to the very top.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

SCR on the slides is SCQA with the question left implicit. The Decision Card is SCQA with the Answer moved to line one (BLUF) and the ask made explicit at the end.

The one-pager is the top of the pyramid; the appendix is the layers of supporting logic beneath it.

THE RULE — Remember the name: Pyramid Principle (SCQA) and BLUF.

Situation → Complication → Resolution (Minto's SCQA, with the question implicit)

BEFORE — chronological (what actually happened, in order)

"At 02:14 on Tuesday the payment queue started backing up. The on-call engineer was paged at 02:20 and initially thought it was the database. By 02:45 we had ruled that out and found the certificate on the payment gateway had expired. We renewed it manually at 03:10 and the queue drained by 03:40. About 1,200 payments were delayed. We then looked at why the alert didn't fire and found the expiry check had been disabled in a change in June..."

AFTER — SCQA (what the reader needs, in the order they need it)

SITUATION — Payment certificates renew manually, and an expiry alert is supposed to give us 14 days' warning.

COMPLICATION — That alert was silently disabled in a June change. On Tuesday a certificate expired unnoticed; 1,200 payments were delayed for up to 90 minutes.

(QUESTION — so what do we do about it?)

RESOLUTION — Automate certificate renewal (two days of work) and add a test that fails the build if any expiry alert is disabled. Both done by Friday; I need sign-off to take the change freeze exception.

THE RULE — Situation is what was true, Complication is what changed, Resolution answers the question that raises. Time of day is never the structure.

Lead with the decision, not the analysis — BLUF

BEFORE — the ask is in sentence nine

Subject: Update on the caching work

Hi all, quick update. Over the last three weeks we have been profiling the product-search path. We tried a few things: query optimisation gave us about 15%, index changes another 10%. We then prototyped a read-through cache in front of the catalogue service, which gets p95 from 1.8 s to 420 ms in the test environment. There is a cost implication of roughly \$900 a month for the cache cluster. We also need a decision on the invalidation approach. Given the launch is in five weeks, we would need approval on this by Friday to make it. Let me know if you have questions.

AFTER — bottom line up front

Subject: DECISION NEEDED by Friday — approve \$900/month cache for search launch

I need approval by Friday for a \$900/month cache cluster; without it, product search will not meet the launch target in five weeks.

Why: the cache takes search p95 from 1.8 s to 420 ms (target: 500 ms). Query and index work got us only 25% of the way.

Decision needed: approve the \$900/month, and choose time-based invalidation (my recommendation) over event-based (page 2 has the comparison).

Analysis and test results attached.

THE RULE — BLUF: if the listener stops after one sentence, they must already know what you want and by when.

The Decision Card — five lines, every time

DECISION NEEDED

What you want the listener to decide, by when — and who the Approver is (DACI, Chapter 6).

SITUATION

What is true and agreed. One or two lines. No surprises here.

COMPLICATION

What changed or what is at risk. The reason we are talking.

RECOMMENDATION

What you propose, with the one number and the one alternative you rejected.

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU

The specific action: approve, choose, assign, confirm.

FILLED IN — the caching decision

DECISION NEEDED — Approve \$900/month cache cluster by Friday. Approver: head of engineering.

SITUATION — Product search launches in five weeks with a 500 ms p95 target.

COMPLICATION — Current p95 is 1.8 s. Query and index tuning recovered only 25%.

RECOMMENDATION — Read-through cache, time-based invalidation: 420 ms in test. Event-based invalidation rejected: three extra weeks.

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU — Approve the spend; confirm time-based invalidation is acceptable to the catalogue team.

THE RULE — The Decision Card is SCQA with the answer moved to line one. Fill it before the deck, the memo or the meeting.

03

Make the technical land

Explaining a concept to a non-technical stakeholder, choosing the diagram, and presenting numbers.

- 01 Know the room
- 02 Structure the message
- 03 Make the technical land**
- 04 Hold the room under pressure
- 05 Deliver it live and remote
- 06 Write it down: the decision memo
- 07 Rehearse and critique

Make the technical part land

THE GOAL

The message is structured. Now the hard content inside it — a concept, a diagram, a number — has to arrive intact in a head that does not have your background.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Explain a technical concept to a non-technical stakeholder using anchor → contrast → consequence.
- Choose between five diagram types for the point being made, and reject the wrong one.
- Present cost, latency, risk and confidence with a unit, a comparison and a confidence range.

Feynman Technique · Zelazny's chart method · the "So what?" test

Feynman Technique (attributed to Richard Feynman); Gene Zelazny, "Say It With Charts" (McKinsey, 1985); Simon Brown's C4 model for the context view; the "So what?" test from Minto.

1

Feynman — explain

Explain it to a 12-year-old. Where you reach for jargon, that is the gap. Simplify, then use an analogy.

2

Zelazny — message first

Write the message as a sentence. The sentence names the comparison; the comparison names the chart.

3

C4 — context view

System in the middle, neighbours around it. The standard "what talks to what" picture in software.

4

"So what?" — numbers

Every number must survive the reader asking "so what?". Unit, comparison, confidence is how it survives.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

Anchor → Contrast → Consequence is the Feynman analogy step, made repeatable. The diagram chooser is Zelazny's method cut down to five chart types. The numbers pattern is the "so what?" test with a checklist.

THE RULE — Remember the name: Feynman Technique · Zelazny's chart method · the "So what?" test.

Explaining a concept: anchor → contrast → consequence (the Feynman analogy step)

BEFORE — correct, and useless to her

Finance director: "What is this cache you keep mentioning?"

"So a cache is basically an in-memory key-value store that sits in front of the database and serves reads for hot data, so you avoid the round-trip and the query cost. We would use a read-through pattern with TTL-based invalidation, so staleness is bounded by the TTL, which we would set to something like five minutes."

Finance director: "...right."

AFTER — three steps, and she can now make a judgement

"ANCHOR — It is like keeping this month's price list on your desk instead of walking to the archive every time someone asks.

CONTRAST — Right now every search walks to the archive: 1.8 seconds. With the desk copy it is under half a second.

CONSEQUENCE — The desk copy can be up to five minutes out of date. For prices that change daily, that is acceptable; for stock levels it would not be, so we do not cache those."

Finance director: "So it is fast for prices and live for stock. Fine."

THE RULE — Feynman: where you reach for jargon, that is the gap. Anchor to something they know, contrast old with new, then say the consequence they must judge.

Explaining why you cannot commit yet: the spike

BEFORE — the word "spike" explained with more jargon

Sponsor: "Why can't you give me a date?"

"Because the integration with the pricing feed is unknown until we do a spike — a time-boxed investigation — since their API documentation doesn't cover rate limits or the pagination behaviour, and until we know that we can't estimate the ingestion stories properly."

AFTER — and it ends with the sponsor making a decision

"ANCHOR — Before quoting a building job, a good builder opens one wall to see what is behind it.

CONTRAST — For most of this project we know what is behind the wall. For the pricing feed we do not: their documentation leaves out how much data they let us pull and how fast.

CONSEQUENCE — We spend one week opening that wall. On Friday week I give you a date I will stand behind. If I give you one today, it is a guess with a 3-week error bar."

Sponsor: "Take the week."

THE RULE — Never explain a term with another term. Anchor, contrast, consequence — then let them decide.

Presenting a number: the "So what?" test

BEFORE — a number with nothing around it

"Latency is about 900 milliseconds."

"The live feed is expensive."

"There's some risk with the vendor."

"We're pretty confident in the estimate."

Each of these is true. None of them survives the reader asking "so what?" — there is nothing to compare to and no idea how sure you are.

AFTER — unit, comparison, and how sure you are

"Search latency is 900 ms at the 95th percentile — nearly double our 500 ms target, and about what users notice as a pause."

"The live feed costs \$180k a year against \$40k for the nightly feed — 4.5×, for prices that are fresher by at most a day."

"The vendor risk is specific: their contract is unsigned. If it slips two weeks, launch slips two weeks."

"The estimate is 5 sprints, ± 1 . The uncertainty is the feed integration; the rest is well understood."

THE RULE — Every number gets three companions: a unit, a comparison the listener already holds, and a confidence range. That is how it passes "so what?".

04

Hold the room under pressure

What to say when you do not know, and how to answer an objection without answering the heat.

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Stay useful when the room pushes back

THE GOAL

The presentation went fine. Then someone asks the thing you do not know — or the thing they are angry about. What you say in the next ten seconds decides whether the decision survives.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Answer a question you cannot answer using acknowledge → bound → commit, without guessing or stalling.
- Separate an objection's content from its heat, and answer the content.
- De-escalate hostile questioning while keeping the decision on the table.

ABC bridging and LAER — the two scripts for pressure

ABC (Acknowledge · Bridge · Communicate) from media and spokesperson training. LAER (Listen · Acknowledge · Explore · Respond) from Carew International, the standard objection-handling model in sales training.

1

A — Acknowledge

Say what you do not know, or what they are feeling. Do not skip this.

2

B — Bridge

Move to what you do know: the bound, the fact, the number.

3

C — Communicate

The commitment: what they will get, by when.

4

LAER for objections

Listen fully. Acknowledge the content. Explore — "is there something from last time?" Respond to the requirement, not the heat.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

Acknowledge → Bound → Commit on the next slides is ABC bridging with the bridge made concrete (a number). Separate → Answer → Check is LAER: the Explore step is the "check" question at the end. The five hostile moves are LAER under sustained pressure.

THE RULE — Remember the name: ABC bridging and LAER.

The question you cannot answer — ABC bridging

BEFORE — the three bad reflexes

CFO: "What exactly will year two cost?"

GUESS: "Um, probably around the same, maybe a bit more, I'd say \$320k-ish?"

(Now \$320k is the number in her notes.)

STALL: "That's a really good question. There are a lot of factors. It depends on volume, and on the vendor's pricing review, and we haven't fully..."

(She stops listening at "it depends".)

DEFLECT: "I'd have to check with the team."

(She hears: you did not prepare.)

AFTER — honest, bounded, and it keeps the meeting moving

CFO: "What exactly will year two cost?"

ACKNOWLEDGE — "I don't have an exact year-two figure."

BRIDGE (to a bound) — "What I can tell you: year one is fixed at \$103k. Year two depends on volume; at our current growth it is between \$105k and \$125k. It cannot exceed \$140k without a contract change you would sign."

COMMUNICATE (the commitment) — "I will send you the year-two model with the three volume scenarios by Thursday."

CFO: "Thursday is fine. Go on."

THE RULE — ABC: acknowledge what you do not know, bridge to what bounds it, communicate when they will have the rest. Never guess.

The objection — LAER: answer the content, not the heat

BEFORE — fight or fold

Head of Operations, sharply: "So you're just going to hand my team a new system with no training and walk away, like last time?"

FIGHT: "That's not fair — last time wasn't our fault, ops didn't attend the sessions we offered."

(Now it is an argument about last time.)

FOLD: "You're right, sorry, we can delay if you want."

(Now the decision is gone.)

AFTER — listen, acknowledge, respond, explore

Same question.

LISTEN, then ACKNOWLEDGE the content — heat: "like last time", "walk away". Content: "no training", "who supports it after go-live". "Two things you're asking..."

RESPOND — "Training: two sessions in the week before go-live, run by us, in your team's shift pattern. Support after: my team is on the call for every page for the first two weeks, then a handover you sign off — not me."

EXPLORE — "Does that cover the concern, or is there something from last time I should design for?"

Ops: "Put the two weeks in writing and I'm fine."

THE RULE — Every objection has a content and a heat. LAER the content; let the heat go past you.

When it stays hostile: five moves

Move	What it sounds like	When
Name the shared goal	"We both want this live without your team getting paged at night."	First response to any hostility
Slow down, lower volume	Same words, half the speed, quieter. Never match their pace.	Throughout
Convert the attack into a requirement	"So the requirement is: no go-live without a signed handover. I can commit to that."	When the content is legitimate
Bound what you will not do	"I won't agree to delay today, because the licence lapses. I will agree to the handover condition."	When they push for a fold
Park it, with an owner and a time	"That is a real question and not one for this room. Can you and I take it tomorrow at 10?"	When it is off-topic or personal

THE RULE — Hostility is usually a requirement that has not been written down yet. Write it down, out loud.

Role-play: the hostile stakeholder (LAER in practice)

HOW IT RUNS

Groups of four. Cards on the slide after next: PRESENTER · HOSTILE STAKEHOLDER · PROCEDURAL STAKEHOLDER · OBSERVER.

The scenario: a cloud-cost decision (reserved instances, \$180k/yr saving, one-year commitment). Presenter has the one-pager on the next slide.

Presenter opens with the Decision Card (under a minute). Then the two stakeholders question, from their cards. Observer scores.

Three rounds; rotate so everyone presents once.

Debrief after each round using the observer card (two slides ahead) — one thing that worked, one move to try.

WHAT A GOOD ROUND LOOKS LIKE

Hostile: "You're locking us into a year we can't get out of, so your numbers look good."

Presenter (slower, quieter): "We both want the saving without a trap. The content of what you're asking is exit risk. The commitment is for 60% of our footprint, not all of it — the part that has not changed in two years. If we shrink, we lose at most \$22k of the \$180k."

Presenter: "Would a written cap on the committed share cover the concern?"

Hostile: "Put it at 50% and I'm in."

Observer notes: named shared goal ✓ · separated content ✓ · converted to a requirement ✓ · kept the decision ✓

The presenter’s one-pager

DECISION NEEDED	Approve a one-year reserved-instance commitment covering 60% of our compute footprint, by Friday. Approver: Head of Platform.
SITUATION	Compute runs ~\$61k/month on on-demand pricing. The committed share of the footprint has been stable for two years.
COMPLICATION	Finance flagged 22% year-on-year cloud growth. Staying on-demand costs ~\$180k/yr more than reserving the stable share.
RECOMMENDATION	Reserve the stable 60% only: \$180k/yr saving. If we shrink, worst-case exposure is \$22k of the \$180k. Rejected - 100% commit (locks growth in), spot-only (SLA risk on customer-facing services).
WHAT I NEED FROM YOU	Approve the commitment; confirm the 60% cap in writing with procurement.

Two minutes with this page, then you open with it as a spoken Decision Card - under a minute.

Role cards and the observer sheet

PRESENTER

- Open with the Decision Card, spoken, under a minute - the ask has a date
- Concede conditions if you must; never concede the decision
- Close by repeating the ask, word for word

PROCEDURAL STAKEHOLDER

- “Has procurement reviewed the exit terms on this contract?”
- “Which committee owns a commitment of this size - and have they seen it?”
- Legitimate questions, calmly asked - you are not the enemy

HOSTILE STAKEHOLDER - USE ALL THREE, IN ORDER

- 1 “You’re locking us into a year we can’t get out of, so your numbers look good.”
- 2 “Last year’s ‘stable’ workloads moved twice. Why is this time different?”
- 3 “When this goes wrong, is it your budget that takes it, or mine?”

OBSERVER - TICK AND QUOTE ONE MOMENT

- Named the shared goal · separated content from tone
- Converted the objection into a requirement
- Kept the decision - conceded only conditions
- The ask restated at the close, with its date

05

Deliver it live and remote

Voice, pace and presence in the room; camera, screen and attention when you are remote.

- 01 Know the room
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Deliver it so it lands

THE GOAL

The same words, delivered differently, get a different decision. Three deliberate techniques for the room, and a checklist for the screen.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Apply three techniques for voice, pace and presence: the pause after the ask, one idea per breath, eyes on the decider.
- Set up and run a remote presentation — camera, screen share, attention — from a printed pre-flight checklist.
- Hold attention remotely with a named interaction every few minutes.

The 3 Vs — Verbal, Vocal, Visual

Standard presentation-skills model derived from Albert Mehrabian's work on congruence. Teach the three channels; do not teach the "7–38–55" percentages — they are a misreading of the original study.

1

Verbal

The words. Chapters 1–3 did this: decision first, one idea per sentence.

2

Vocal

Pace, pause, volume. One idea per breath; the pause after the ask; louder for the headline and the ask.

3

Visual

Eyes, feet, hands, camera. Eyes on the decider; planted feet; camera at eye level; one window shared.

4

Congruence

When the three disagree, the listener believes vocal and visual over verbal. A confident sentence said fast, to the floor, reads as doubt.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

Pause · Breathe · Look are the three techniques — one vocal (pause), one vocal (breath), one visual (eyes). The remote pre-flight checklist is the Visual channel for a camera.

THE RULE — Remember the name: The 3 Vs.

Vocal: the pause after the ask

BEFORE — no pauses, and the ask is buried by the next sentence

"So-the-recommendation-is-to-move-to-the-managed-service-before-March-it's-\$310k-over-three-years-and-what-I-need-from-you-is-approval-today-and-also-a-contract-owner-um-so-shall-I-go-through-the-alternatives-now-or-I-can-also-cover-the-cost-breakdown-first-whichever-is-easier..."

The ask went past at speed, followed immediately by an offer to keep talking. Nobody had to answer it. Nobody did.

AFTER — one idea per breath, and silence after the ask

"The recommendation is to move to the managed service before March.
[pause]

It is \$310k over three years. [pause]

What I need from you today is approval — and a name on the finance side for the contract. [long pause — eyes on the CFO — say nothing]"

CFO: "...Approved. Priya will own the contract."

The silence after the ask is the question. Filling it takes the question back.

THE RULE — One idea per breath. After the ask, stop talking and look at the person who decides.

Three techniques, and what each one fixes

Technique (channel)	Do this	It fixes
Pause after the ask (vocal)	Say the ask. Stop. Count three. Look at the decider. Do not offer to continue.	The ask being washed away by the next sentence; the decision never being made
One idea per breath (vocal)	Finish a sentence, breathe, start the next. Full stops are audible.	Run-on delivery that sounds nervous and loses the listener mid-thought
Eyes on the decider (visual)	Know who decides before you start. Deliver the ask to them, not to the slide or the room.	Talking to the screen; the decider feeling they can defer
(Feet — visual)	Planted, shoulder-width, no swaying. Hands free of the clicker when you are not clicking.	Visible nervousness that the room reads as uncertainty about the content
(Volume — vocal)	Slightly louder than conversation for the headline and the ask; conversational for the rest.	Everything sounding equally important — so nothing does

THE RULE — You do not need to be a performer. You need three deliberate habits, and the first one is silence.

Presenting remotely: the visual channel through a camera

BEFORE — a real review call, described

Camera on the laptop, below chin level; ceiling light behind. Sharing the entire screen: seventeen tabs, a chat window, a notification about lunch. Reading from notes off to the left, so eyes never meet the camera. Eleven minutes of unbroken talking. Ends with "any questions?" to a grid of muted faces. Silence. "OK, I'll take that as a yes."

It was not a yes.

AFTER — the same content, set up to be decided

Camera at eye level, light in front. Sharing ONE window — the one-pager — not the screen. Notes on a sticky note beside the camera so eyes stay near the lens. Names used: "Priya, this next number is the one you asked about." A question to a named person every few minutes. Ends: "Daniel, you are the decider here — do we have approval, or what do you need to see?"

Daniel: "Approved. Send the test summary."

THE RULE — Remotely, attention has to be taken, by name, every few minutes — it is never given.

The remote pre-flight checklist

BEFORE — 10 minutes out

Camera at eye level; light in front, not behind

Share ONE window, never the screen; close everything else

Notifications off (and the lunch reminder)

One-pager open; appendix files ready to switch to

Names of the decider and each stakeholder written beside the camera

Sticky note with the ask, word for word, beside the lens

DURING — every few minutes

Say a name: "Priya, this is the number you asked about."

Ask a named question: "Daniel, does that match what finance expected?"

Pause after the ask; look at the lens, not the grid

If two cameras go off, stop and ask: "I have lost some of you — should I zoom out?"

Stop sharing when you ask for the decision — faces, not slides

ENDING — never "any questions?"

Address the ask to the named decider

"What do you need to see for a yes?"

Confirm the decision back in words: "So that is approved, with the handover condition."

Say what you will send and when

Post the decision in the chat before anyone leaves

THE RULE — Share one window, use names, and stop sharing when you ask for the decision.

06

Write it down: the decision memo

The decision memo: the written form of everything above, and the record people act on later.

- 01 Know the room
- 02 Structure the message
- 03 Make the technical land
- 04 Hold the room under pressure
- 05 Deliver it live and remote
- 06 Write it down: the decision memo**
- 07 Rehearse and critique

Write the decision down

THE GOAL

Meetings end. What survives is the memo: the record that gets forwarded, argued with and acted on by people who were not in the room. It is the Decision Card, in full sentences.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Write a one-page decision memo: decision needed, recommendation, options with trade-offs, risks and assumptions, what happens next.
- Convert a Decision Card into memo sections without adding analysis the reader did not ask for.
- Review a peer's memo against a checklist and give one specific rewrite.

The narrative memo, DACI and the ADR

Amazon's narrative memo ("6-pager", Bezos, 2004 — no slides in the room, everyone reads first). DACI (Driver · Approver · Contributor · Informed) from Intuit/Atlassian. ADR — Architecture Decision Record (Michael Nygard, 2011).

1

Narrative memo

Full sentences, not bullets, so the reasoning is visible. Ours is one page, not six; the structure is the same.

2

DACI — who decides

Name the Approver in section 1. If you cannot, you do not yet know who you are writing to.

3

Options + do nothing

Every rejected option gets its why-not. "Do nothing" is always an option with a consequence.

4

ADR — the bridge

Context · Decision · Consequences. The memo's sections 3, 2 and 5 in Session 12's format.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

The seven-section memo is a one-page narrative memo. The decision memo names the Approver (DACI) in section 1. In Session 12 the same content becomes an ADR.

THE RULE — Remember the name: The narrative memo, DACI and the ADR.

The decision memo: seven sections, one page

1 DECISION NEEDED	One sentence: what, by whom (the DACI Approver), by when.
2 RECOMMENDATION	What you propose and the one number.
3 CONTEXT	Situation + complication, three or four lines.
4 OPTIONS CONSIDERED	Each option: one line of what it is, one line of why not. Include "do nothing".
5 RISKS AND ASSUMPTIONS	What could make this wrong, what you assumed, who confirms it.
6 WHAT HAPPENS NEXT	If approved: first three actions, owners, dates. If not: the consequence.
7 APPENDIX POINTERS	Where the evidence lives.

FROM CARD TO MEMO

Decision needed → section 1, verbatim, with the Approver named.

Situation + Complication → section 3.

Recommendation → section 2, plus the rejected alternative expanded into section 4.

What I need from you → section 6, as actions with owners.

New in the memo: section 5 (risks and assumptions) and "do nothing" as an option. Both exist because the reader was not in the room and cannot ask.

Length: one page of prose, not bullets — Amazon's rule. If it is longer, you have put analysis in it. Analysis goes in the appendix.

THE RULE — The memo is written for the person who was not in the room. Every section answers a question they cannot ask you.

The memo, worked - the caching decision

1 • DECISION NEEDED

Approve a \$900/month cache cluster for product search by Friday. Approver: Head of Engineering.

2 • RECOMMENDATION

Read-through cache with time-based invalidation - p95 420 ms in test against the 500 ms target.

3 • CONTEXT

Search launches in five weeks with a 500 ms p95 target; current p95 is 1.8 s. Query and index tuning recovered 25% and is exhausted.

4 • OPTIONS CONSIDERED

Event-based invalidation - three extra weeks, misses launch. Further tuning - diminishing returns.
Do nothing - launch misses the target and the retail commitment.

5 • RISKS AND ASSUMPTIONS

Prices can be up to five minutes stale in the cache. Assumes the catalogue team accepts time-based invalidation - they confirm by Wednesday.

6 • WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

If approved: provision cluster (platform, Mon) · load test at launch volume (search, Wed) · catalogue sign-off (Wed). If not: the do-nothing consequence goes to the launch committee.

7 • APPENDIX POINTERS

Load-test dashboard · cost comparison sheet · tuning history.

THE RULE One page of prose, written for the person who was not in the room - analysis lives in the appendix.

A decision memo, annotated: choosing the message queue

DECISION MEMO — Message queue for the order pipeline

1 DECISION NEEDED — Approve the platform-standard queue for the order pipeline by 12th, so Sprint 3 can start on it. Approver: head of engineering.

2 RECOMMENDATION — Use the platform-standard queue. No new licence; \$0 incremental; supported by the platform team.

3 CONTEXT — Orders currently call the warehouse synchronously; customers wait up to 6 s and see errors when the warehouse is slow. A queue lets us confirm in ~1 s and deliver to the warehouse when it is ready.

4 OPTIONS — (a) Standard queue: recommended, above. (b) Managed queue from cloud vendor: 30% lower operating effort but needs a platform exception and a security review (3 weeks). (c) Do nothing: 6 s waits continue; error rate stays at 2.1%.

5 RISKS AND ASSUMPTIONS — Messages can wait up to 1 h if the warehouse is down; product has confirmed 1 h is acceptable (assumption A1, owner: product lead, confirmed 3rd). Standard queue capacity at peak assumed sufficient (A2, owner: platform team, unconfirmed — test by 10th).

6 WHAT HAPPENS NEXT — If approved: platform team provisions the queue (by 14th); we build the producer (Sprint 3); peak test (by 10th, before approval). If not approved by 12th: Sprint 3 starts on lower-value work and the 6 s wait ships in the release.

7 APPENDIX — A: latency measurements. B: option comparison. C: peak-capacity test plan.

WHAT MAKES IT WORK

Section 1 has a date, a reason for the date, and a named Approver.

Section 2 has the number even when the number is \$0.

Section 3 is four lines. Not a history.

"Do nothing" is an option with a consequence.

Every assumption has an ID, an owner and a status.

"If not approved" is spelled out — the reader sees the cost of not deciding.

It fits on one page. The analysis is in A, B, C.

The same decision, written badly

BEFORE — a memo with no decision in it

Subject: Queue thoughts

Hi, following up on the discussion about the queue. As you know we've been having issues with the warehouse calls for a while now. I looked into a few options. The managed one is nice and has lower ops overhead but I think the platform team might have opinions. The standard one is fine too. There's also the question of what happens if the warehouse is down for a long time, which we should probably discuss with product at some point. Anyway, let me know what you think, happy to go through it in more detail whenever.

AFTER — what the reader would have needed

Everything the bad version is missing:

- No decision requested, no date, no reason for a date, no Approver.
- No recommendation — "fine too" is not a recommendation.
- Options are described, not compared, and "do nothing" is absent.
- The one real risk (1 h wait) is raised and then abandoned — "at some point".
- No next actions, no owners.
- "Let me know what you think" hands the work to the reader.

Six weeks later nobody can say why the queue was chosen — because nobody chose it.

THE RULE — A memo that ends in "let me know what you think" is not a decision memo. It is a request for someone else to write one.

Memo, deck, email or decision record — which one?

Vehicle	Use it when	Do not use it when
DECISION MEMO (narrative)	A decision must be made by someone who may not be in a meeting, and must be traceable later	You need a live conversation to reach it — send the memo first, then meet
DECK	You are in the room and need the audience to follow a sequence — one point per slide	Someone will read it without you; a deck without a presenter is a bad memo
EMAIL	A small, reversible ask with a deadline; a status where no decision is needed	The decision is significant — email threads lose the reasoning
ARCHITECTURE DECISION RECORD (ADR)	A technical design choice that future engineers must understand: context, decision, consequences (Session 12)	The audience is non-technical — send them the memo, link the ADR

THE RULE — Match the vehicle to the decision. When in doubt: memo first, meeting second, deck only in the room.

07

Rehearse and critique

How to rehearse in three passes and how to give critique someone can actually use.

- 01 Know the room
- 02 Structure the message
- 03 Make the technical land
- 04 Hold the room under pressure
- 05 Deliver it live and remote
- 06 Write it down: the decision memo

07 Rehearse and critique

Rehearse properly, critique properly

THE GOAL

Nobody delivers a first draft well. Three passes of rehearsal find what a mirror cannot — and critique is only useful when it names something the presenter can change.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER YOU CAN

- Run a three-pass rehearsal — dry run, timed run, hostile run — and record what changed between passes.
- Give and receive critique using a rubric, one observed behaviour per criterion, in the form observed → effect → suggestion.
- Commit to three specific changes for your next real presentation.

SBI feedback and deliberate practice

SBI (Situation · Behaviour · Impact) from the Center for Creative Leadership. Deliberate practice from Anders Ericsson: practice that targets a specific weakness, with immediate feedback, repeated.

1

S — Situation

When and where. "In the timed run, at the ask..."

2

B — Behaviour

What you saw or heard, quoted. Not an interpretation.

3

I — Impact

What it did to you as a listener. "I did not know I was being asked."

4

+ Deliberate practice

One suggestion, tried immediately, in the next pass. That is what makes three passes worth more than three run-throughs.

HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THIS CHAPTER

Observed → Effect → Suggestion is SBI with the Situation folded into the quote and a suggestion added. Dry → Timed → Hostile is deliberate practice: each pass targets a different weakness and the feedback is immediate.

THE RULE — Remember the name: SBI feedback and deliberate practice.

Three passes, three different questions

Pass	How	The question it answers	What you change afterwards
1 DRY RUN	Alone, out loud, standing. No slides. Just the Decision Card.	Can I say it without reading?	The words you stumbled on — usually a sentence with two ideas in it
2 TIMED RUN	With slides, to one colleague, clock visible. Deliver the ask; stop.	Does the ask arrive before the room's patience runs out?	Cut whatever came before the ask that the ask did not need
3 HOSTILE RUN	The colleague plays the most difficult stakeholder, from a card, with three prepared objections.	Does the decision survive contact?	The bound and the commit for each objection — written down, now in the appendix

THE RULE — Rehearsal without a hostile pass tests the part that was never going to fail.

Critique that can be used: SBI, plus one suggestion

BEFORE — kind, vague, useless

"Yeah, that was good. Really clear. Maybe just... slow down a bit? And I think the middle section could be tighter. But overall good, I'd say confident, just maybe a bit more energy. Nice slides."

The presenter has learned: nothing they can act on. "Slow down" — where? "Tighter" — which part, cut what? "More energy" — how?

AFTER — two specific things, each one changeable

"OBSERVED (situation + behaviour) — After you said 'what I need from you is approval', you immediately said 'so, shall I go through the alternatives?'"

EFFECT (impact) — The CFO never had to answer the ask. She didn't.

SUGGESTION — Say the ask, then stop and look at her for three seconds. Try it now."

[Presenter does it. It works.]

"OBSERVED — Slide 4 had the 4-second lag figure with no target beside it.

EFFECT — I couldn't tell if 4 s was bad. SUGGESTION — Put 'target: 1 s' next to it."

THE RULE — SBI: what you saw (situation, behaviour), what it did to you (impact), then one thing to try. Nothing else counts.

The critique rubric — four criteria, one observation each

Criterion	What "good" looks like	Write ONE observed behaviour
MESSAGE	Decision first; SCQA audible; the ask is specific and has a date	Quote the sentence where the ask arrived (or did not)
EVIDENCE	Every number has a unit, a comparison and a confidence; the diagram makes the point	Name one number or diagram and what it did or did not tell you
HANDLING	Unanswerable questions bridged and committed (ABC); objections answered on content (LAER)	Quote one question and the first sentence of the answer
DELIVERY	Pause after the ask; one idea per breath; eyes on the decider (the 3 Vs)	Name the moment you saw one of the three (or its absence)

THE RULE — One observation per criterion, quoted. If you cannot quote it, you did not observe it.

Ten names to take home

1

Power–Interest grid

who gets the ask, who gets the appendix

2

BLUF

bottom line up front — the answer is line one

3

Zelazny's chart method

write the message; it names the chart

4

ABC bridging

acknowledge, bridge, communicate — for what you do not know

5

The 3 Vs

verbal, vocal, visual — and congruence between them

2

Pyramid Principle / SCQA

situation, complication, question, answer

3

Feynman Technique

explain it simply; the jargon is the gap; then an analogy

3

The "So what?" test

unit, comparison, confidence on every number

4

LAER

listen, acknowledge, explore, respond — for objections

6–7

Narrative memo • DACI • ADR • SBI

write it as prose, name the approver, record it, critique it